

ADVANCING FIRST CLASS PRE-K IN ALABAMA

A Decade of Perfect Tens: Where Does Alabama Pre-K Stand in the Nation?

Quality benchmarks, enrollment, and state spending across 51 jurisdictions, 2016–2025

JoonHo Lee and Alison Hooper ■ August 2026

Alabama's First Class Pre-K is routinely described as one of the highest-quality state pre-K programs in the country. In this brief we examine what that reputation looks like in the national data, comparing Alabama with the other 50 states and the District of Columbia on quality standards, enrollment, and state spending. We assembled a 51-jurisdiction panel from the National Institute for Early Education Research (NIEER) *State of Preschool* yearbooks and focus on the 2025 edition (the 2024–25 school year). On quality standards we find Alabama's record singular: it is the only state to have met all 10 of NIEER's current quality benchmarks in every year since the framework was adopted in 2016. On access we observe a different picture, as 40.3 percent of Alabama's four-year-olds are enrolled, 18th among the 51 jurisdictions.

Four patterns stand out:

- **Alabama holds the only unbroken benchmark record of the current era.** Six states met all 10 benchmarks in 2024–25, itself a record high, although Alabama alone has done so in each of the 10 years since the 10-benchmark framework took effect (figure 1).
- **Access is mid-pack.** With 24,238 four-year-olds enrolled, or 40.3 percent, Alabama ranks 18th of 51 jurisdictions (figure 2) and 8th among the 17 Southern jurisdictions (table 1).

- **Balance across the three dimensions is rare.** Only three states clear the national median on both enrollment and per-child state spending while meeting all 10 benchmarks: Alabama, Georgia, and Michigan (figure 3).
- **High standards have not required the nation's highest price.** Meeting every benchmark does not require the highest per-child spending: Alabama spends \$7,651 per enrolled child, while Michigan, the other long-streak benchmark state, spends \$13,604.¹

These comparisons are descriptive: they summarize program standards, enrollment counts, and reported spending rather than classroom practice or child outcomes, and we return to their limits at the end of the brief.

The National Context for Alabama's Pre-K Debate

Alabama's pre-K conversation increasingly turns on how far and how fast to expand, and national comparisons discipline that conversation in both directions. Some states have expanded without holding standards, as Florida enrolls 63.2 percent of its four-year-olds yet meets only 5 of 10 quality benchmarks, while others hold standards without expanding, as Mississippi meets all 10 benchmarks while enrolling 22.8 percent. Although Alabama has so far stayed off both paths, that balance may not be self-sustaining, and we offer these comparisons as an evidence base for the expansion debate ahead.

This brief is the fourth in the *Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama* series, and it extends our earlier work on access (Hooper and Lee 2025) and on classroom funding (Lee and Hooper 2026a, 2026b) by placing the program in its national context.

BOX 1

Data and Methods

Data. We assembled the NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbooks into a 51-jurisdiction panel covering 2002 through 2025 (school years 2001–02 through 2024–25), and we take the 2025 edition as the primary year, excluding Guam and the “national” summary rows.

Quality benchmarks. NIEER scores each program against 10 minimum policy standards covering teacher and assistant credentials, professional development, class size and staff–child ratios, learning standards, curriculum supports, screening and referral, and continuous quality improvement. Because the 10-item framework dates to 2016 and earlier years used a smaller checklist, the streaks we report never cross that revision. A state's score is enrollment-weighted across its programs.

Measures. Enrollment is the share of each state's four-year-olds served by state pre-K, and spending is state pre-K dollars per enrolled child in the yearbook's inflation-adjusted 2025 dollars. We report ranks out of all 51 jurisdictions; 46 operated a program in 2024–25, and Alabama is 18th on enrollment

either way. All of our results are descriptive: policies, counts, and dollars, not classroom quality or program effects.

Benchmark Records under the Current Framework

When NIEER adopted its current 10-benchmark framework in 2016, Alabama met all 10 standards in that first year and in each of the 10 years since, a record no other state holds (figure 1).

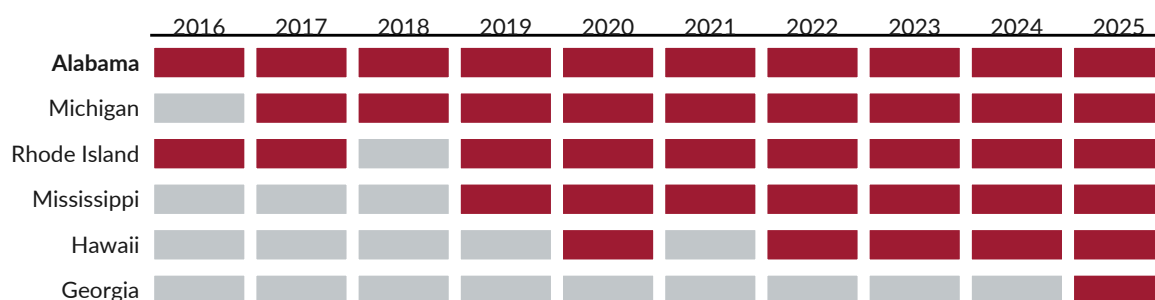
Michigan and Rhode Island come closest, meeting all 10 in 9 of the 10 years, while Mississippi has met the full standard for 7 years running and Hawaii has met it in 5 of the 10 years. Georgia, the largest program among the six benchmark states, reached all 10 for the first time in 2024–25, and that six states now hold perfect scores is itself notable, because the group has never been this large.

For Alabama the implication runs in two directions. The claim of quality without interruption remains intact, as figure 1 shows at a glance. Yet the group of states meeting every benchmark is growing, so quality standards alone may distinguish Alabama less with each passing year.

FIGURE 1

Alabama Is the Only State with a Perfect Benchmark Record Since 2016

Years in which each of the six 2024–25 benchmark states met all 10 NIEER quality benchmarks, 2016–2025



Source: Authors' analysis of NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbook data, 2016–2025 editions.

Notes: Crimson cells mark years meeting all 10 benchmarks; gray cells mark years meeting fewer. The six states shown are those meeting all 10 in 2024–25—itself a record high. Because the benchmark checklist changed in 2016 (from 8, then 9, to 10 items), records are not compared across that revision.

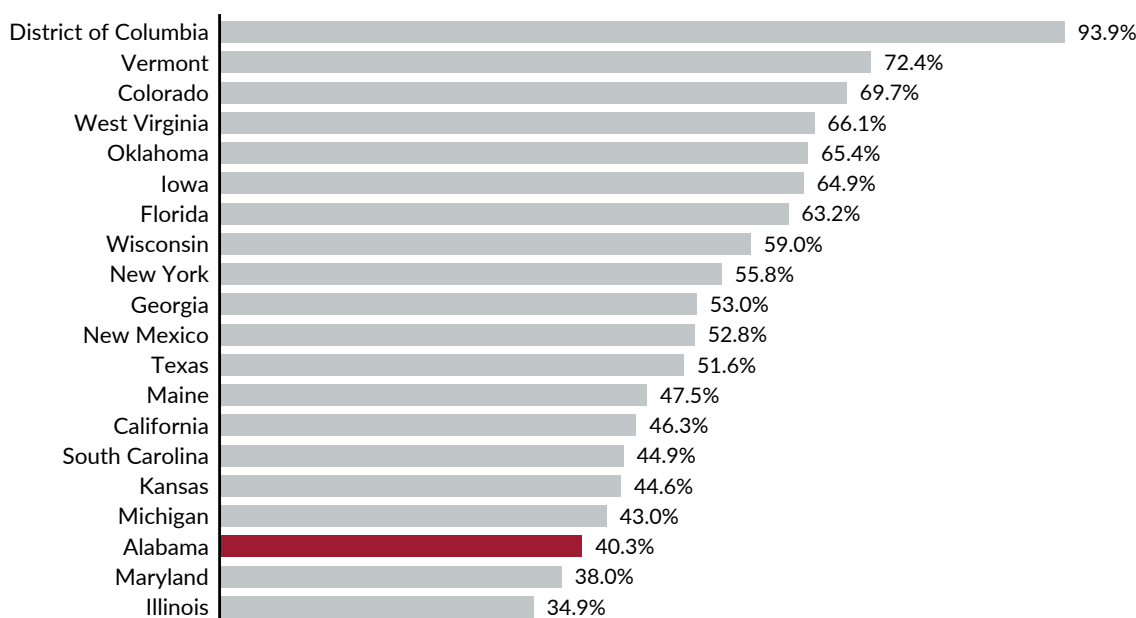
Enrollment of Four-Year-Olds across the Nation

Although Alabama leads the nation on quality standards, we find that leadership is not associated with a comparable position on enrollment. In 2024–25, First Class Pre-K served 24,238 four-year-olds, or 40.3 percent of the state’s four-year-olds, placing Alabama 18th of 51 jurisdictions (figure 2). The District of Columbia (93.9 percent), Vermont (72.4 percent), and Colorado (69.7 percent) lead the jurisdictions ahead of Alabama, and of the 17 with higher enrollment shares, only Georgia and Michigan also meet all 10 quality benchmarks.

FIGURE 2

Seventeen Jurisdictions Enroll a Larger Share of Four-Year-Olds

Share of four-year-olds enrolled in state pre-K, top 20 of 46 operating jurisdictions, 2024–25



Source: Authors’ analysis of NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbook data, 2025 edition.

Notes: Alabama in crimson. Five states did not operate a state pre-K program in 2024–25 and are excluded.

Within the South, Alabama’s 40.3 percent ranks 8th of 17 jurisdictions (table 1), behind high-enrollment programs such as Oklahoma, Florida, Georgia, and Texas and ahead of Mississippi, North Carolina, and Tennessee.

Access, Spending, and Benchmarks Together

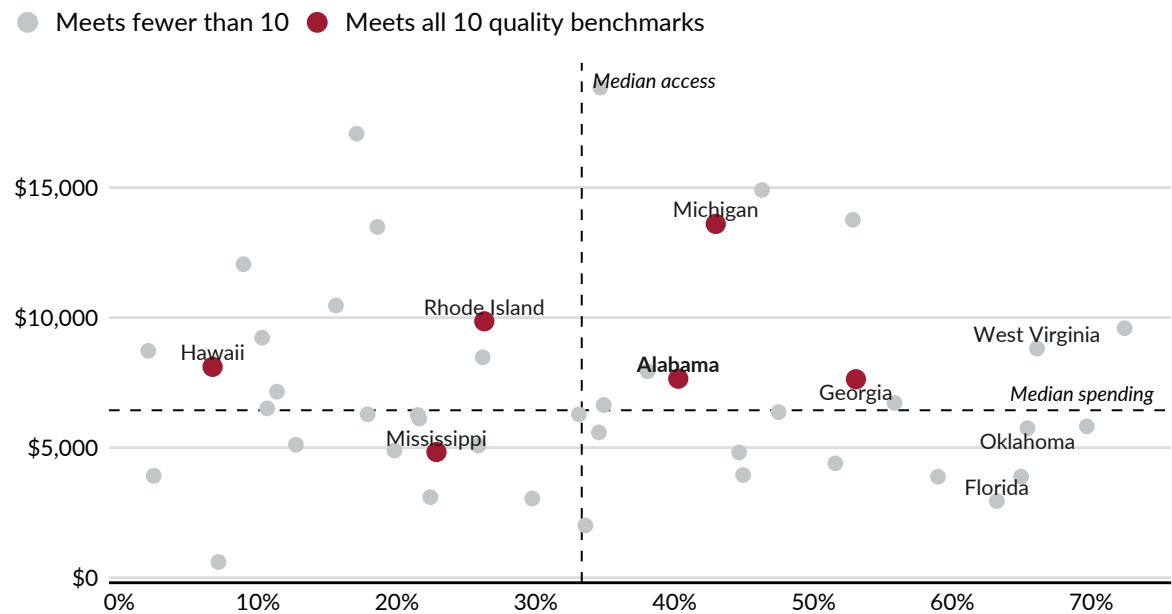
In figure 3 we place the three dimensions on a single plane for 2024–25. Each point is an operating jurisdiction positioned by enrollment share and per-child state spending, and crimson points mark the

states meeting all 10 benchmarks. The upper-right quadrant—above the median on both access (33.3 percent) and per-child spending (\$6,437)—contains only three benchmark states: Alabama, Georgia, and Michigan.

FIGURE 3

Alabama Sits in the Rare Upper-Right Corner

Per-child state spending and share of four-year-olds enrolled, 45 operating states, 2024–25



Source: Authors' analysis of NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbook data, 2025 edition.

Notes: Dashed lines mark medians across operating jurisdictions. Spending is state pre-K spending per enrolled child in 2025 dollars. The District of Columbia (93.9 percent enrolled; \$27,354 per child) is omitted from the plot area for scale but included in the medians and in all ranks.

The remaining quadrants are instructive: high-access states such as Florida (63.2 percent) and Oklahoma (65.4 percent) sit below the spending median, and Florida meets half the quality benchmarks, while high-spending states such as New Jersey (\$18,848) and Oregon (\$17,072) meet fewer than 10. Meeting all 10 benchmarks is therefore not reliably associated with high spending or high enrollment, since only three of the six benchmark states clear both medians; reaching all three at once may be the harder achievement.

The Southern Context

The same tradeoff appears within Alabama's own region (table 1).

TABLE 1

In the South, Only Georgia Pairs Higher Enrollment with All 10 Benchmarks

State pre-K enrollment, spending, and benchmarks, 17 Southern jurisdictions, 2024–25

Jurisdiction	Enrolled	Share of 4-year-olds	State \$ per child	Benchmarks
District of Columbia	13,040	93.9%	\$27,354	4
West Virginia	13,674	66.1%	\$8,810	9
Oklahoma	36,114	65.4%	\$5,749	9
Florida	150,607	63.2%	\$2,946	5
Georgia	70,572	53.0%	\$7,630	10
Texas	248,483	51.6%	\$4,395	2
South Carolina	30,586	44.9%	\$3,947	7
Alabama	24,238	40.3%	\$7,651	10
Maryland	34,003	38.0%	\$7,933	7
Louisiana	19,884	34.5%	\$5,584	8.8
Arkansas	20,327	33.1%	\$6,278	8
Kentucky	18,837	25.9%	\$5,080	8
Mississippi	8,076	22.8%	\$4,832	10
Virginia	24,425	21.6%	\$6,120	5
North Carolina	26,707	21.5%	\$6,254	9
Tennessee	17,501	19.8%	\$4,886	9
Delaware	1,418	8.9%	\$12,052	9

Source: Authors' analysis of NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbook data, 2025 edition.

Notes: Census South region. Benchmark scores are enrollment-weighted across a state's programs, so multi-program states can show fractional values. Alabama's per-child state spending ranks 5th of the 17.

Three Southern jurisdictions meet all 10 benchmarks: Georgia, Alabama, and Mississippi. Within the region, higher enrollment is not consistently associated with higher benchmark scores, since Florida enrolls 63.2 percent while meeting 5 benchmarks and Mississippi enrolls 22.8 percent while meeting all 10. Alabama is distinctive in pairing the full standard with above-median access, which among Southern states only Georgia also does, and Georgia reached all 10 only this year.

Discussion

Our comparisons suggest that Alabama's quality record and its enrollment position raise different questions. On standards the state's position is secure, though no longer unique in kind; on access it sits near the middle of the national distribution. Georgia, next door, enrolls 53 percent of its four-year-olds and, as of 2024–25, meets all 10 benchmarks, so in at least one comparable state expansion did not come at the cost of a weaker standard. We would not read a single case as evidence that the two are

compatible everywhere, although it does suggest that the national data pose a question to Alabama's expansion debate rather than a brake on it.

Access is the dimension on which Alabama has the most room to move, and the arithmetic there is straightforward: each percentage point of four-year-old enrollment represents roughly 600 children, so moving from 40.3 percent toward a share like Georgia's 53 percent is likely a question of seats and sites, the subjects of the next briefs in this series, rather than of program design.

The quality distinction may meanwhile require active maintenance, because six states now hold perfect scores and the group has never been larger. Alabama's unbroken record is likely an asset for recruitment, federal grant-seeking, and public trust, but streaks continue only if the policies behind the benchmarks, among them staffing ratios and teacher credentials, stay funded as the program grows.

Limitations

These analyses have several limitations. NIEER's benchmarks are policy standards rather than observed practice, recording what a state requires of degrees, ratios, and curriculum supports rather than what happens in classrooms; classroom observation data, which may bear more directly on practice, are the subject of separate work. Enrollment shares also depend on each state's estimated four-year-old population, and modest revisions to that denominator shift the shares even though they would likely leave Alabama's broad position unchanged. Per-child spending is likewise a quotient of total dollars over enrollment, so it moves when either term moves, and it excludes local and federal streams unless noted; the all-streams, price-adjusted comparison is available only through 2023. Finally, every comparison we report is descriptive: rankings do not measure program effects, and nothing here estimates the impact of pre-K on children.

Despite these limitations, we think the descriptive record supports a clear reading. A decade into the current national quality framework, Alabama is the only state that has met every benchmark in every year, and the question it now faces is less about its standards than about the number of children it serves.

Notes

¹ Per-child figures divide each state's total pre-K spending by its enrollment, in the yearbook's inflation-adjusted 2025 dollars, so they reflect both appropriations and enrollment counts. Counting all reported funding streams and adjusting for regional price parities—possible only through the 2023 data year—Alabama stood at \$12,094 per child, 10th of 51 and well above the national average of \$8,284.

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ABOUT THIS PROJECT

The Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama project examines First Class Pre-K funding, implementation, access, and comparisons with other state pre-K programs. Its goal is to offer recommendations for expanding First Class Pre-K while maintaining high levels of quality.

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